SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #93 · CHURCH & AUTHORITY

“Leaving a church means leaving God.”

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Where it often comes from

Being told that anyone who leaves is backsliding or rebellious. Deep loyalty to a church family. Fear of losing friends or community. Leaders who warned of God’s judgment on those who leave. Harm or unhealthy patterns in a church that make staying painful.

What Scripture teaches

God never leaves His children, wherever they worship. Jesus said He is with even two or three gathered in His name. Scripture encourages believers to keep meeting together, so leaving one church should usually mean finding another, not leaving fellowship altogether. Sometimes there are good reasons to move to a different church: moving, doctrine, or unhealthy leadership. God warns shepherds who scatter the flock. Your relationship with God is not owned by any one congregation.

> *“Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’”* **(Hebrews 13:5)**.

Also see

> “For where two or three gather together in My name, there am I with them” **(Matthew 18:20)**.

> “And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching” **(Hebrews 10:24–25)**.

> “I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down His life for the sheep” **(John 10:11)**.

> “‘Woe to the shepherds who destroy and scatter the sheep of My pasture!’ declares the LORD” **(Jeremiah 23:1)**.

Common self-statements

- If I leave, God will leave me.
- Leaving means I’m rebelling against God.
- My faith depends on this church.
- I’ll lose God if I lose these people.
- God will punish me for leaving.
- There’s no other place for me to worship.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing staying equals faithfulness and leaving equals rebellion.
- **Overgeneralization:** Treating one church as if it were the whole body of Christ.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Staying out of fear rather than conviction.
- **Confusing institution with God:** Assuming loyalty to a church is the same as loyalty to Christ.

Challenging questions

- Does God promise to stay with me wherever I go?
- Where is Jesus when two or three gather in His name?
- Is my reason for leaving about following God more closely?
- Am I leaving fellowship, or looking for healthier fellowship?
- What does God say about shepherds who scatter the flock?
- Who could give me wise counsel about this decision?
- How can I leave in a way that honors God?

Truth summary

> Leaving a church does not mean leaving God. God never leaves me or forsakes me. My relationship with Him is not owned by one congregation. I can seek a healthy church where I can grow, keep meeting with other believers, and follow Jesus wherever He leads.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Guidance
- Will of God
- Friendship
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Backsliding
- Truth

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Leaving a church means leaving God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Leaving a church means leaving God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Does God stay with me wherever I go?
- ☐ Where is Jesus when believers gather?
- ☐ Am I leaving to follow God more closely?
- ☐ Am I looking for healthier fellowship?
- ☐ Who could counsel me on this?
- ☐ How can I leave in a God-honoring way?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God will never leave me nor forsake me.
- ☐ My relationship with God is not owned by one church.
- ☐ Jesus is with believers wherever they gather.
- ☐ I can seek a healthy church and keep meeting with believers.
- ☐ God cares about how His sheep are treated.
- ☐ I can follow Jesus wherever He leads.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Hebrews 13:5**
  "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'"
- [ ] **Matthew 18:20**
  "For where two or three gather together in My name, there am I with them."
- [ ] **Hebrews 10:24–25**
  "And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching."
- [ ] **John 10:11**
  "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down His life for the sheep."
- [ ] **Jeremiah 23:1**
  "'Woe to the shepherds who destroy and scatter the sheep of My pasture!' declares the LORD."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Fellowship log:** Each week, write one way I connected with other believers, in any setting.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Hebrews 13:5 becomes: "God has said to **Sarah**: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Church" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write down your reasons for staying and for leaving,** and pray over both lists.
- ☐ **Talk with a wise Christian outside your church** about your decision.
- ☐ **Visit another healthy church** and notice what you experience.
- ☐ **If you leave, do so kindly,** and stay connected with friends who will support your walk with God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Leaving a church means leaving God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One way I connected with believers
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Leaving a church means leaving God.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You never leave me or forsake me. Help me reject the lie that leaving a church means leaving You. Give me wisdom about where to worship, courage to follow You, and a healthy community where I can grow. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.